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THA 211: Dramatic Literature and Criticism - From Aristotle to Soyinka

Read plays critically and argue about them without summarising the plot

THEATRE & FILM

Theatre & Film Studies

Faculty of Arts
Theatre & Film Studies | 200L

OUTLINE ARCHIVE: 2018 - 2019 - 2025/2026

Written for students, by students.

Practical notes, worked examples, practice questions and a revision plan.

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Why this pack exists

Criticism is an argument about how a play works, supported by evidence from the text. This pack covers classical and modern critical standpoints, the vocabulary of dramatic analysis, and a repeatable method for writing a critical answer that goes beyond plot summary.

This is a student-written study companion, not a reproduced lecture handout or a leaked examination paper. Use it to organise the topics you are taught, practise the kind of thinking your course rewards, and walk into class with better questions.

What you will be able to do

- Apply Aristotle's poetics and later critical standpoints to a play.
- Analyse dramatic structure, character, language and staging implications.
- Distinguish description, interpretation and evaluation in criticism.
- Build a critical argument supported by textual evidence.

How to use this pack

1. Skim the whole pack once in 20 minutes so you know what is inside.
2. Work through one section at a time with your lecture note and recommended text beside you.
3. Attempt the practice questions before reading the answers. Mark what you missed.
4. Use the final checklist to plan your revision week, one tick per study session.

> **Free to download, always**
> This pack is free. There is no fee, no subscription and no payment step before download, and the full PDF is not watermarked or locked. Share the link with a coursemate instead of forwarding the file.

> **Confirm your official course outline**
> Course codes, credit units and outlines can differ by department and session. Treat this pack as supplementary support and confirm the current outline with your lecturer, course rep or departmental handbook before an assessment.

Critical standpoints

Each standpoint asks a different question of the same play.

- Classical: plot, character, thought, diction, song and spectacle; unity of action.
- Neoclassical: rules, decorum and the unities, later challenged by Romantic practice.
- Romantic and modern: expression, symbol and the director's interpretation.
- Marxist: class relations, ideology and the economic conditions of production.
- Feminist and postcolonial: gender, power and the politics of representation.
- Semiotics: signs, codes and how performance produces meaning.

> **Name the standpoint**
> If you use a postcolonial reading, say so. Naming the lens turns a set of opinions into a method.

Analysing a play

Use a checklist so you do not drift into retelling.

- Structure: act and scene divisions, turning points, use of time.
- Character: function, relationships, what each character wants and fears.
- Language: register, imagery, rhythm, silence.
- Stagecraft implied by the text: setting, props, entrances, offstage action.
- Context: the conditions of first production and the play's reception.
- Theme: what the play argues, not merely what it is about.

Writing the critical answer

Marks follow argument structure.

1. Open with a claim that answers the question directly.
2. Define the critical term you are using.
3. Give a quotation or specific moment as evidence.
4. Explain how the evidence supports the claim.
5. Acknowledge a counter-reading and answer it.
6. Close by returning to the question, not to the plot.

Criticism is an argument, not a verdict

A weak drama essay tells the examiner what happens and then announces that the play is good. A strong essay makes a claim that someone could disagree with and then proves it from the text. "Death of a Salesman is a tragedy because Willy Loman dies" is a plot summary; "Death of a Salesman works as tragedy because Miller makes Willy responsible for his own collapse while denying him the recognition that would make that responsibility meaningful" is an argument.

The difference matters because criticism exists to explain how a text produces its effects. Your evidence is always the same three things: what is said (dialogue), what is done (action and stage business), and how it is arranged (structure, staging, the sequence of information). Anything not traceable to one of those is your opinion, which is allowed, but must be labelled as such.

Aristotle is useful for structure and dangerous when treated as a checklist. The requirement that a tragic action be serious, complete and of a certain magnitude is a tool for testing whether a play holds together, not a licence to list six elements and award marks to Sophocles. Use one concept from a theorist to do one job in your argument, and say what that job is.